



Student Academic & Leadership Excellence Awards

SALEA 2026



Step-by-Step POE Guide: Award Criteria and Nomination Questions

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SECTION A

i. Definitions

*** Nominee**

A nominee is a student or student group being put forward for an award in recognition of their contributions. They are the individuals whose work, service, or impact is being evaluated. Nominees can be proposed by others or can nominate themselves.

*** Nominator**

A nominator is the person who submits a nomination on behalf of someone else. This could be a fellow student or staff member who believes the nominee meets the award criteria and deserves recognition.

*** Self-nomination**

Self-nomination occurs when a student puts themselves forward for an award. In this case, the student completes the nomination form and assembles the required Portfolio of evidence to showcase their own impact. Self-nominations are allowed and encouraged if the student can provide credible evidence aligned with the award criteria.

*** Co-curricular (or Co-curriculum) Activities**

These are structured learning experiences that are connected to academic learning and often organised by the university.

*** Extra-curricular Activities**

These are activities students take part in outside of their formal academic program and are usually not directly linked to curriculum outcomes. They contribute to personal growth, social development, and wellbeing.

Examples: Sports, arts and culture clubs, student societies, volunteering, House committee, GCI, Insika or Qhakaza representative.

ii. **Developing a Portfolio of Evidence (PoE): A Comprehensive Guide**

A Portfolio of Evidence (PoE) is a structured collection of documents and supporting materials that showcase the work, achievements, and impact of an individual or team. In the context of the Student Academic & Leadership Excellence Awards, the PoE serves as proof of contributions, activities, and outcomes that align with the award criteria.

The primary purpose of the PoE is to provide credible, authentic, and traceable evidence of performance, leadership, innovation, teamwork, and service excellence. It enables the evaluation panel to conduct a thorough and transparent review of each nominee's impact.

The PoE is used by both nominators and nominees to support their application or nomination. It is submitted during the awards nomination phase and assessed by a panel of evaluators to determine eligibility and the level of impact made by the candidate(s). For example, if a residence advisor is nominated for demonstrating outstanding leadership, the PoE might include photos from events they organized, thank-you letters from students, and reports detailing their initiatives. This helps the evaluation committee to gain a deeper understanding of their work. Additionally, the PoE may serve as a reference for the university in the future, illustrating the positive contributions made by the nominee.



Here's a simple outline to help you develop a Portfolio of Evidence (PoE):

a) Clarify requirements and purpose.

The first step in constructing a strong PoE is to clarify the specific requirements and purpose. Nominees and nominators should begin by thoroughly familiarising themselves with the relevant award criteria, including what categories are available and the expectations associated with each.

b) Gather evidence.

- Collect a variety of evidence, including reports, meeting minutes, plans, attendance registers, photos, and other supporting documents.
- Visual evidence includes photographs, movies, diagrams, and charts. Testimonials include letters of recommendation and comments from peers, superiors, and stakeholders.
- Performance data includes statistics, metrics, survey findings, and performance reviews.
- Artefacts include samples of work, project deliverables, and prototypes.

c) Format and Presentation

Maintain a consistent format and style throughout the document to ensure clarity and professionalism. Use appropriate terminology and neat formatting to enhance readability. The presentation should be visually clean and logically structured. Where appropriate, multimedia elements such as photographs or video stills may be included to enhance the evidence being presented, but they should support the content, not overwhelm it.

d) Ensuring Authenticity and Credibility

All evidence included in the PoE must be legitimate and verifiable. Avoid making assumptions or including hearsay. Use trustworthy sources and include citations where relevant. Supporting documents such as signed letters, attendance registers, official reports, or third-party confirmations add credibility to your evidence and make it easier for evaluators to trust and understand your submission.

e) Review and Revision

Before submitting, review the PoE to ensure that all information is accurate, up to date, and relevant. The language used should be clear and concise, avoiding unnecessary jargon or overly technical terms unless they are necessary for context. Carefully proofread the entire document for spelling, grammar, and punctuation errors. A well-edited PoE reflects professionalism and attention to detail.

f) Submission Preparation and Compliance

Ensure that the PoE complies with all submission rules and requirements. If both physical and digital submissions are required, prepare them accordingly. Digital versions should be submitted in accessible formats, such as PDF, to allow for easy review by evaluators. Finally, keep copies or backups of all materials included in your PoE to safeguard against any technical or physical loss.

iii. Testimonial Structure:

- * Letterhead – Must include department/institution/organisation details.
- * Date – Clearly shown at the top.
- * Greeting and Title – e.g., “To Whom It May Concern”
- * Introduction – Who is writing the testimonial and in what capacity.
- * Description of the Nominee’s Role – What the nominee did, how they demonstrated leadership, innovation, or service.
- * Examples – Specific contributions or incidents that stand out.
- * Closing Statement – Endorsement of the nominee for the award
- * Signature – Full name, role/title, and signature of the testimonial writer

iv. Report structure:

- I. Cover page
 - Title of the Report
 - Name of Nominee

- Name of Nominator (if applicable)
 - Award Category
 - Department/Residence/Organisation
 - Date of Submission
2. Table of Contents
- Automatically generated or manually created (e.g., using Microsoft Word)
 - Lists each section with page numbers for easy navigation.
3. Brief overview of what the report will cover.
- Purpose of the nomination
4. Background
- Description of the context or situation that led to the project or initiative.
 - Overview of the nominee's environment (residence, campus club, community, etc.)
 - The gap or challenge the nominee sought to address.
5. Narrative: Description of Activities
- A detailed, story-style account of what the nominee did
 - Emphasis on leadership, innovation, and service
 - Include:
 - Roles and responsibilities
 - Planning and execution
 - Participation and teamwork
 - Obstacles and how they were overcome.
 - Use strong action words: led, organised, initiated, developed, supported, improved.
6. Achievements and Impact
- Tangible outcomes of the work (e.g., number of students reached, initiatives completed, improvements made)
 - Feedback received (can include quotes from surveys or emails)
 - Awards, recognition, or positive changes that resulted.
 - Graphs, tables, or visuals may be used to enhance understanding.
7. Conclusion
- Closing statement
 - Final statement on why the nominee deserves the award.

SECTION B: NOMINATION QUESTIONS

I. Criteria & Nomination questions

The C Awards are represented in the following categories:

- Dean 'of students Prestigious Award
- Sportsmanship Award
- Promotion of Healthy Lifestyle Award
- Exemplary Society/Club/Structure Award
- Outstanding Residence Life Award
- Student Entrepreneurship Award
- Emerging Leader (First Year Student)
- Diversity and Inclusion

I.1 Dean 'of students Prestigious Award

The Dean of student's award recognizes individuals who have demonstrated outstanding achievements in various areas of their academic life, aligning with the DUT ENVISION2030 strategic plan and values.

The recognition of the Dean of Students Prestigious Award includes:

- i) Academic excellence with a minimum aggregate requirement (E.g., 75% or above). Performance, involvement academic advising/workshops, tutorials, or any other core academic activities. (assisting others in the classroom)
- ii) Leadership
 - * Evidence of leadership roles in student led initiatives.
 - * Positive influence and mentorship of peers.
- iii) Community Engagement (society)
 - * Active participation in community service or outreach programs aimed at improving lives and livelihood.
 - * Demonstrated commitment to social responsibility and civic engagement.
- iv) Innovation and Creativity
 - * Developed creatively and innovatively contributed towards solutions within the university or community.
 - * Demonstrated entrepreneurial spirit and creativity.
- v) Commitment to University Values
 - * Alignment with the university's mission, values, and goals.
 - * Active promotion of a positive campus culture and environment.
 - * Participation in university events and initiatives.
- vi) Personal Growth and Development
 - * Demonstrated commitment to personal growth and self- improvement.

1. Section A: Academic Excellence

1.1 Upload your latest academic transcript or progress report that shows an aggregate of 75% or above.

1.2 Provide narrative of how the nominee urgency for academic excellence testimonials

Attached Evidence:

1.1

- * Academic transcript (official, stamped)
- * Certificate of merit (Dean merit certificate)

1.2

- * Testimonials from lecturers and tutors showing engagement in co and/or extra curriculum activities.

2. Section B: Leadership

2.1 Describe your involvement in leadership roles in student-led initiatives.

Share an example of a project or initiative you started or led that positively impacted other students or the broader community.

2.2 How have you used your influence to positively impact your peers? Provide specific examples.

Word Limit: Not more than 500 words.

Attached Evidence:

- * Recommendation letter
- * Event Poster
- * Post-program report
- * Attendance registers and feedback reports (pre and post survey reports)
- * Photos or videos from events
- * Testimonials or recommendations

3. Section C: Community engagement

3.1 Describe the community service or outreach programs you have been involved in. (aim and objectives)

3.2 How have your contributions improved the campus environment or the surrounding community?

3.3 In what ways have you demonstrated a commitment to civic engagement or social responsibility? Word Limit: Not more than 500 words.
Attached Evidence: * Signed testimonial. * Event schedule and topics covered. * Attendance registers * Photos or videos from outreach events * Certificate of participation
4. Section D: Innovation and creativity 4.1 Share an example of an innovative plan/project that you developed to address or enhance current processes and procedures in DUT or in your community. Narrative Word Limit: Not more than 500 words
Attached Evidence: * Attached Evidence: * Signed testimonial. * Attendance registers * Photos or videos * Prototype or project report (demo)
5. SECTION F: Commitment to University Values 5.1 Describe how your actions align with DUT's values and principles outlined in ENVISION2030. 5.2 In what ways have you promoted a positive campus culture? 5.3 List at least three DUT initiatives highlighting DUT living values framework. Word Limit: Not more than 500 words
Attached evidence. * Signed testimonials. * Project reports
6. SECTION G: Personal Growth and Development

6.1 Describe your journey of personal growth and self-improvement during your time at DUT. 6.2 What challenges have you faced and overcome in your academic or personal life? How did you grow from those experiences? Word Limit: Not more than 500 words
Required document. * Reflection essay * Certificates

I.2 Sportsmanship Award

The Sportsmanship Award recognises a team or individual who has demonstrated outstanding performance, teamwork, and exemplary sportsmanship during the recognition period from 1 July 2025 to 30 June 2026. The award is given to those who exhibited exceptional sportsmanship character during their participation in competitions.

Recognition criteria include:

- i) Have participated in competitions/ leagues with good progression towards winning.
- ii) Good academic performance with an aggregate of 65% for individuals and 60% average for teams.
- iii) Have demonstrated/ exhibited the DUT living values.

I. Demonstrated Sportsmanship: Describe specific incidents or consistent behaviors that demonstrate the nominee's integrity, fairness, respect for opponents, and positive attitude in sport settings. - Outline track record of participation in competitions where the nominee/s have obtained placement Narrative Word Limit: 300 words
Attached document: * Testimonial from coach, official, or team manager * Match reports or official commendations. * Attach academic records of nominees

2. Leadership in Sport: Outline the nominee's/ team's leadership roles in sports teams, clubs, or sporting events. Narrative Word Limit: 300 words
Required Documents: * Testimonial from coach or team manager/ league organizers * Team captaincy records
3. Impact on Team and Community Culture: Describe how the nominee/ team members' have contributed to fostering unity, teamwork, and sports culture within DUT or the community. Narrative Word Limit: 300 words
Required Documents: * Testimonials from teammates * Post program reports. * Photos or evidence of team-building initiatives * At least 3 reflective essays of no more than 500 words, individual/ collective peer support
4. Alignment with DUT ENVISION2030 Values: Reflect on how the nominee's/ Team's behavior and impact in sports aligns with DUT's core values and principles. Narrative Word Limit: 300 words
Required Document: * Endorsement letter from Sport officer/Unit, coach, lecturer, or student governance body
5. Supporting Evidence (Checklist)
☐ Testimonials ☐ Certificates and awards ☐ Match Reports ☐ Photographs of Initiatives ☐ Attendance Registers ☐ Feedback Reports

- | |
|--|
| ☐ Outreach Documentation
☐ Endorsement Letter |
|--|

I.3 Promotion of Healthy Lifestyle Award

The Promotion of Healthy Lifestyle Award recognizes individuals, groups or societies who have contributed to promoting health and wellness within DUT. Their initiatives have an impact on DUT Community's physical, mental, and emotional well-being.

The criterion for recognition includes:

- i.) Evidence of organizing or promoting wellness activities, workshops, or programs on campus (E.g., of events or initiatives that encourage physical, mental, and emotional well-being).
- ii.) Good track record of academic performance with an aggregate of 65% in the recognition period
- iii.) Demonstrated positive impact on the health & well-being of peers.
- iv.) Introduction of new & creative approaches to wellness, and implementation of innovative wellness strategies or programs.
- v.) Active collaboration with university departments, student organisations, or external partners (E.g. Joint initiatives and partnerships to enhance wellness efforts.
- vi.) Efforts to create sustainable wellness practices.
- vii.) Initiatives that continue to benefit the DUT Community over time.

- | |
|--|
| I. Describe a wellness activity, initiative, or Program that the nominee organized, led, or promoted on campus (e.g., Event or initiative that encourages physical, mental, and emotional well-being.) |
|--|

Narrative word limit: Not more than 300 words.

Required document:

- | |
|---|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none">* Event Poster* Proposal of activities and events hosted or organized. |
|---|

2. Report/s on the positive impact the nominee's wellness activities have had on the DUT community at large. Narrative word limit: Not more than 300 words.
Required document: * Pictures * Feedback reports * Attendance registers * Testimonials
3. Describe a project the nominee has collaborated with other units/departments within the university. Narrative word limit: Not more than 300 words.
Required document. * Implementation plan * Attendance registers and feedback reports * Post survey report
4. Checklist: Annexures & Supporting Documents
☐ Project proposal ☐ Project Reports ☐ Photographs of Initiatives ☐ Attendance Registers ☐ Testimonial Letters ☐ Feedback Reports ☐ Project plans

1.4 Exemplary Society/Club/Structure Award

Exemplary Society/Club/Structure Award recognizes student clubs/structures, societies, or student-led networks that have shown extraordinary dedication, participation, and influence within the DUT.

community. Clubs/Structures include ones focused on student activist, culture, arts, volunteering, and other similar activities. Recognition criteria include:

- i) Conceptualized and implemented campus initiatives aligned with ENVISION2030.
- ii) Contributed to Impactful initiatives, enhancing student life and community involvement.
- iii) Demonstrates commitment to cultivating an inclusive and vibrant community, encouraging active participation from both existing and potential members.
- iv) Uses creative and unique approaches to achieve club objectives by thinking out of the box and trying out new ways to meet their aims and objectives.
- v) Collaboration with other student organizations and academic departments
- vi) Good academic performance with an aggregate of 65% for individuals and 60% average for groups.

1. Describe how the nominee/ group have driven university activities (project/activity) aligned with ENVISION2030.

1.1 How have this campus activities contributed towards the realization of ENVISION2030

1.2 List a minimum of three key campus projects the club has led/ driven, outlining impact.

Narrative word limit: Not more than 500 words.

Required document:

- * Narrative report on the impact of initiatives/ programs, aligned with the ENVISION2030 strategic objectives.
- * Photos, posters, or program draft (as additional evidence)

2. Provide evidence of impactful initiatives led by the nominee/s that has enhanced the DUT student life and community involvement (Provide a descriptive narrative & upload supporting information)

2.1 Specify the output and outcomes of the activities/engagements.

Narrative word limit: Not more than 500 words.

Required document.

- * Testimonials (students/community)
- * Attendance registers, program evaluation, and impact measures
- * Event outcome reports
- * Photos & videos

3. Explain how the nominee has demonstrated commitment to cultivating an inclusive and vibrant DUT community. (Provide a descriptive narrative & upload supporting information)

Narrative word limit: Not more than 500 words.

Required document.

- * Narrative report with proof of campus vibrancy and active involvement of students
- * Photos or videos from inclusive events

4. Outline specific instances where the nominee used creative and unique approaches to achieve their objectives (Provide a descriptive narrative & upload supporting information)

Narrative word limit: Not more than 500 words.

Required documents.

- * Narrative on creative or innovative approaches towards inculcating vibrancy
- * Multimedia (graphics, videos)
- * Reports

5. Detail any collaborations the nominee has had with other student organizations, student services, academic departments, and external organisations. (Provide a descriptive narrative & upload supporting information)

Narrative word limit: Not more than 500 words.

Required documents

- * Collaboration agreements or communications
- * Joint event reports
- * Photos or flyers showing partnerships.
- * Emails or letters of endorsement

6. List the success/outcomes achieved from the activities/ programs. (Provide a descriptive narrative & upload supporting information)

Narrative word limit: Not more than 500 words.

- * Final report of project/ initiative completion
- * Reports highlighting output and outcomes (with M&E tools)

I.5 Outstanding Residence Life Award

The Outstanding Residence Life Award recognizes a Residence with the most impactful residence life initiatives. The residence needs to have a track record of high attendance in-house and central program and high level of discipline, participation, and involvement. Track record of peer-to-peer support and a nurturing and supportive residence. Residence must have:

- i) High attendance In-House and central programs.
- ii) Exhibited/ demonstrated the DUT living values, with good consequence management measures with the residence.
- iii) Cohesive and inclusive residence, with collective culture of care

I. Provide a report of why this residence deserves the Outstanding Residence Life Award. This should include what were the key achievements of the residence. What makes the residence stand out in terms of student engagement? How would you describe the overall residence culture? What impact have your Residence Life programs had on student well-being and success.

Required document:

- * Document that highlights the achievements detailing student engagement, and the culture of inclusivity and peer support.

2. Outline the programs held detailing progress and impact of the programs

Narrative word limit: Not more than 500 words.

Required document:

- * Residence program reports, include the objectives, outcomes, and themes (may add pictures program and posters as evidence)
- * Plan of Action / Program proposal
- * Attendance registers
- * Testimonials/ Feedback from students

3. Kindly detail how DUT living values are sensitized within the residences. Use examples of cases, highlighting resolution strategies. How was the general handbook and residence code of conduct workshopping to the students

Required documents:

- * 1 page summary of interventions strategies/ best practices
- * Evidence of referrals where applicable

4. Supporting Evidence (Checklist)

- ☐ Plan of Action/Program proposal
- ☐ Program Report
- ☐ Program Posters and Photographs/picture evidence.
- ☐ Attendance Registers
- ☐ Feedback Reports

☐ Recommendations

I.6 Student Entrepreneurship Award

The Student Entrepreneurship Award recognizes individuals who have demonstrated skills in creating and running a successful entrepreneurial project (this may include social, close corporation). This individual is a risk taker, comes up with unique ideas and has a clear vision for their entrepreneurial project.

Criteria for recognition includes.

- i) Demonstrated innovative and creative ideas. Examples of unique value propositions and creative solutions.
- ii) Strong leadership skills and a clear vision. Evidence of strategic planning and goal setting.
- iii) Evidence of personal growth and development as an entrepreneur. Overcoming challenges & continuous learning
- iv) Effective leadership in managing the enterprise team or resources.
- v) Contribution to social responsibility or DUT community well-being.
- vi) Good academic performance with an aggregate of 65% for individuals and 60% average for groups.

I. Describe how entrepreneurial endeavor is original, unique, and relevant to society. What makes your product or service unique in the market, and how does it add value to your customers?

Optional prompts: Include examples of creative approaches, technologies used, or original features.

Narrative Word Limit: 300 words

Attached documents:

- * Product or service brochures/pamphlet
- * Photos or videos of the product/service in use
- * Customer testimonials or feedback
- * Any patents, trademarks, or design registrations (If available)

2. What is your long-term vision for your entrepreneurial project, and how have you demonstrated leadership in turning this vision into a reality?

Word Limit: Not more than 300 words.

Attached documents:

- * Report on viability and sustainability
- * Team or staff testimonials
- * Incubation report
- * Records of business goals and achievements

3. Reflect on your journey as an entrepreneur. What personal challenges have you faced, and how have you grown or developed through them?

Narrative word limit: Not more than 500 words

Attached documents:

- * Reflective essay

4. How do you manage your team or resources to ensure productivity and smooth operations?

Word Limit: Not more than 300 words

Attached evidence:

- * Job descriptions or task allocations
- * Team meeting minutes or schedules
- * Workflow processes or resource tracking tools
- * Project plans

5. In what ways does your entrepreneurial project contribute to social responsibility or support the DUT community?

Optional prompts: Mention any community projects, environmental efforts, donations, mentorships, or other social impact initiatives.

Word Limit: Not more than 300 words

Attached documents.

- ☐ narrative reports (with photos and registers)
- ☐ Testimonials from beneficiaries or community members
- ☐ Letters of collaboration with DUT departments or student groups

I.7 Emerging Leader (First Year Student)

This award recognizes a remarkable sophomore who exemplifies the spirit of transformational leadership, as envisioned in DUT's ENVISION2030 strategy. This student has already demonstrated exceptional potential, initiative, and a deep commitment to people-centeredness, innovation, and collaborative growth. The recipient of this award actively contributes to shaping a sustainable and inclusive environment, inspiring peers through their proactive mindset, resilience, and dedication to lifelong learning. They go beyond expectations, engaging meaningfully with their community and demonstrating the DUT Living Values

This award honours a student who is not only emerging as a leader—but as a future living embodiment of DUT's ENVISION2030 values.

Eligibility Criteria:

- Must have good track record of academic performance, with an aggregate of 65 % in their recent progress report/ results.
- Shows early evidence of leadership potential, influencing others positively, stepping up during challenges, or contributing to team success. As aligned with the LVF
- Engages in continuous learning and development, seeking feedback and growth opportunities.
- Must be in sophomore year or first year in the current academic year.

1.7.1 Attached documents:

- * Required Document: Proof of registration

1.7.2 Describe the leadership roles you have taken in any student organizations, co/extracurricular activities, or community service initiatives. What were your responsibilities and what impact did you have?

Word Limit: Not more than 300 words.

Attached documents:

- * Certificate of participation or leadership
- * Photos or videos of involvement
- * Testimonials from lecturers, peer, or project leaders

1.7.2 How have you demonstrated DUT Living Values? Provide examples of incidents, experiences, or opportunities.

Narrative word limit: Not more than 500 words

Attached documents:

- * Reflective essay
- * Reference letter from lecturer, mentor, or peer

1.7.3 How have you made a positive difference in the lives of other students or within the DUT community? Share specific moments or initiatives that demonstrate your contribution.

Word Limit: Not more than 300 words

Attached evidence:

- * Testimonials from peers or staff

Attached documents.

- ☐ Photos or reports from community service or outreach events
- ☐ Testimonials from beneficiaries or community members
- ☐ Letters of collaboration with DUT departments or student groups

I.8 Diversity and Inclusion Award

The Diversity and inclusion award will encamp various activities, initiatives and practices that foster an institution where everyone feels valued, respected, and included. The initiatives Must create a safe and enabling environment for both students and staff.

The criterion for recognition includes:

- i.) Demonstrate sustained commitment and advocacy for minority or special interest groups.
- ii.) Driven/ led initiatives that promote a cohesive and inclusive campus culture.
- iii.) Track record of collaborations with groups of special interests, departments, and/or units.
- iv.) Good academic performance with an aggregate of 65% for individuals and 60% average for teams.

I.8.1 Describe how the nominee/s has excelled in advocating for minority or special interests' groups

Required document:

- * Project reports (with registers, etc.)

I.8.2 Report on the positive impact the nominee has had on university students and community. Provide evidence.

Narrative word limit: Not more than 300 words.

Required document:

- * Attendance registers and feedback reports
- * Meeting minutes
- * Testimonials

I.8.3 Describe a project the nominee has collaborated with other units and academic departments within the university to advance diversity and inclusion.

Narrative word limit: Not more than 300 words.

Required document.

- * Implementation plan
- * Attendance registers and feedback reports
- * Post survey report.
- * Participation certificate

I.8.4 Supporting Evidence Checklist

- ☐ Certificates and awards
- ☐ Appointment Letters
- ☐ Project Reports
- ☐ Photographs of Initiatives
- ☐ Attendance Registers
- ☐ Testimonial Letters
- ☐ Feedback Reports
- ☐ Project plans
- ☐ Recommendations